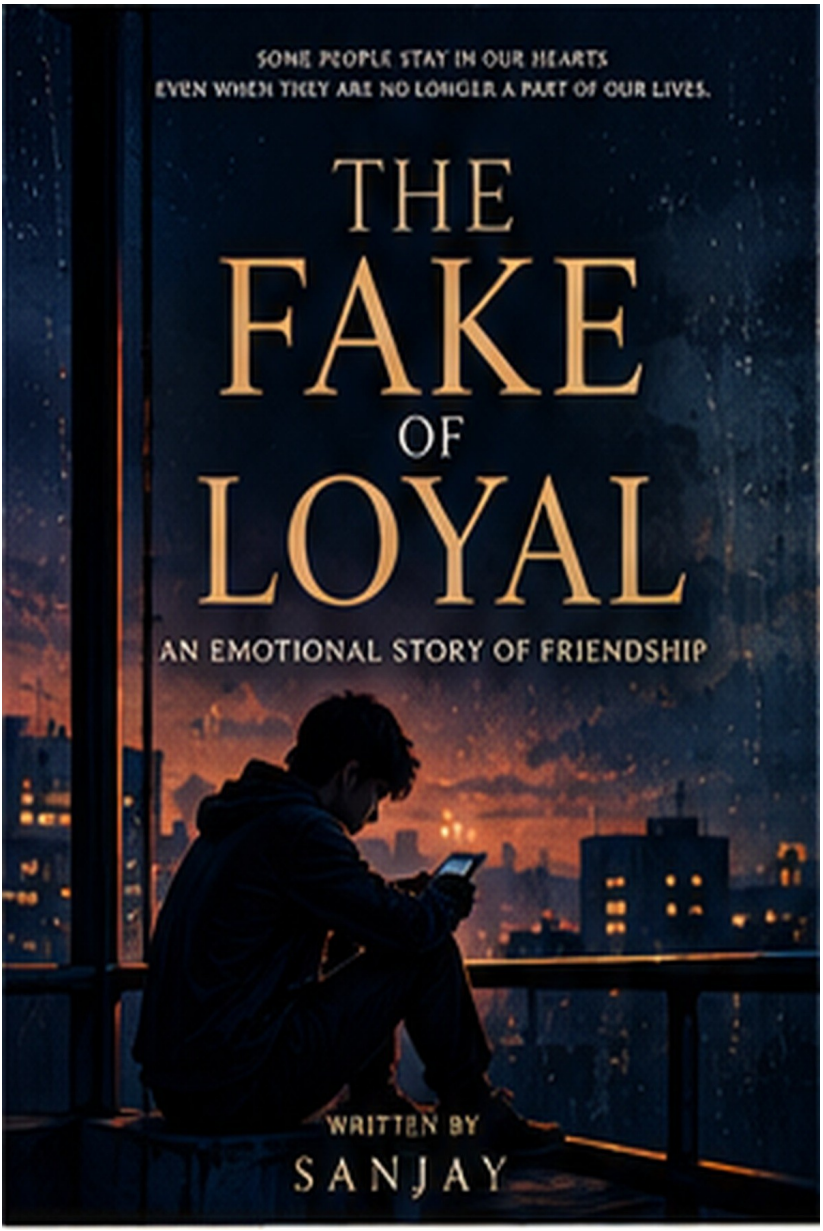

SOME PEOPLE STAY IN OUR HEARTS
EVEN WHEN THEY ARE NO LONGER A PART OF OUR LIVES.
THE
FAKE
OF
LOYAL
AN EMOTIONAL STORY OF FRIENDSHIP
WRITTEN BY
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DISCLAIMER

This book is not written to blame women, girls, or any one gender. Every person is different, and no single story can represent everyone. It explores friendship, trust, attachment, changing priorities, hurt, and feelings that are not always easy to explain. The events are inspired by a real experience, while the characters, names, dialogue, and some narrative details have been imagined or adapted for storytelling. This book shares one person's perspective; it does not claim to tell every side of the story or define what either person felt in every moment. Its purpose is to explore the complexity of a relationship—not to accuse or generalize about anyone.

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CHAPTER 1

The Innocence of Trust

August 24, 2022 — One Request

Shiva and Akshara were in the same class, but being classmates did not mean they knew each other. They shared a classroom and still remained strangers, each living inside a different circle of friends and ordinary school days.

On August 24, 2022, a notification appeared on Shiva's phone: Akshara had sent him an Instagram follow request. He accepted it. A moment later, curiosity won.

"Who are you?" he asked.

The answer connected two facts he had not joined before: they were in the same class. That was all. No long conversation, no promise, no sign that this small exchange would become a memory he would carry for years. The conversation ended that day, as easily as it had begun.

October 24, 2022 — Happy Diwali

Two months passed. Then, on October 24, Shiva sent Akshara a Diwali wish.

"Happy Diwali!"

This time, the conversation did not stop after a few lines. A joke led to another joke. Shiva teased her; she teased him back. The messages became less like a greeting and more like a place they could return to.

Their friendship grew through small things: silly jokes, personal problems, worries they did not share with

everyone, and feelings that were easier to type than to say aloud. Slowly, they became the person the other looked for when a day felt heavy.

At school, classmates teased them as if friendship between a boy and a girl could only mean romance. Some carried stories about Akshara to Shiva and stories about Shiva to Akshara.

“Why are they saying things about us?” they wondered. Neither wanted rumours to define what they had. They kept talking, trying to let the bond be what it was: a friendship that felt safe.

Behind the Screen

They were comfortable in messages long before they were comfortable face to face. Shiva was shy. Akshara noticed and teased him about it, but her jokes made the awkwardness lighter. Behind the screen, he could answer freely and share thoughts he might have swallowed in person.

When Akshara’s birthday arrived in December 2022, Shiva was the first to wish her. The next day, he gave her a watch. She liked it. For Shiva, the gift was not about its price; it was proof that he had remembered and wanted her day to feel special.

A few days later, they spoke more comfortably in person and took selfies across the road from school. Two classmates

standing near a road, smiling at a camera: an ordinary picture that would later hold an entire season of life.

Then Shiva learned that Akshara had a boyfriend, Vicky. Vicky disliked their friendship and told Akshara not to speak to Shiva, threatening to break up if she did. Shiva understood the pressure and stepped back because he did not want to become the reason she lost someone she loved.

In January 2023, Shiva's birthday came. Akshara gave him a bike keychain. It was small, but it told him she had remembered him too.

A THOUGHT TO KEEP

“A four-year story can begin with one notification and a question as small as, ‘Who are you?’”

CHAPTER 2

The Connection He Believed In

When Vicky's Truth Came Out

After school, Akshara began to understand things about Vicky that she had not seen clearly before. Their relationship ended. When she was low, Shiva returned to the role he knew: he listened and stayed available while she tried to recover her confidence.

They joined different colleges. Their days no longer followed the same school timetable, and meeting required more planning. Still, Shiva looked forward to seeing her. In his mind, she was more than a classmate or even a best friend. He had quietly placed her inside the circle he reserved for family.

When Someone Else Arrived

Then a third person entered Akshara's life, and the rhythm changed. Replies grew fewer. Easy conversations began to feel scheduled around other priorities. Shiva told himself that college changes routines and people make new friends. Understanding it in theory did not make it painless.

The distance became arguments. Shiva, who had rarely asked for anything, found himself pleading for the friendship not to end. Akshara said they needed to leave each other. To Shiva, it sounded like a door closing while he was still standing in the doorway.

After a while, they began speaking like strangers. Shiva begged and cried more than once. When the third person's

place in her life ended, the old conversations returned for a time. The familiar tone came back, and Shiva hoped they had found their way back. The happiness did not last; another person entered Akshara's life, and once again Shiva felt his place move to the edge.

A Birthday Near the Mall

In January 2024, Akshara was in her second year of college and preparing for a week-long internship. The day before Shiva's birthday, they met and ate lunch. He was happy to see her, but a small thought stayed with him: tomorrow was his birthday, and she seemed not to remember.

She turned to him between bites and asked, almost casually, "When's your birthday again?"

Shiva looked up. "Tomorrow."

For a second, he waited for her to say she remembered. She only nodded and looked back at her phone.

"I have an internship holiday tomorrow," Akshara said. "I won't be able to meet you."

"It's okay," Shiva replied, trying not to let the disappointment show. "We can meet another day."

He carried that small promise with him through the next morning. He checked his phone more than once, half-expecting a birthday message or a chance to see her.

Later, he learned that Akshara had gone to the mall with the other person. The explanation she had given him the day before no longer made sense.

He typed, erased, and typed again before sending: “You said you couldn’t meet because of the internship. Why did you lie to me?”

Her reply came back sharp. “I don’t have to explain every place I go, Shiva.”

“I’m not asking you to report everything,” he wrote. “You could have just told me the truth. It was my birthday.”

“You’re making this bigger than it is,” she replied. “I can’t keep having the same argument with you.”

The words landed harder than the mall itself. Shiva wanted to explain that he was hurt by the lie, not claiming ownership of her time. But anger crowded the message box, and he sent things he later wished he had phrased differently.

The argument moved faster than either of them seemed able to stop. Then her profile disappeared from his screen. He searched again, tried another way to reach her, and understood that she had blocked him everywhere.

He stared at the chat until the screen dimmed. There was no final message he could answer, no apology he could send,

and no way to ask whether their friendship had really ended like this.

Akshara said the internship would be on holiday the next day, so they would not be able to meet. Shiva accepted it. But the next day, Akshara went to a mall with the other person. Later, Shiva learned that she had not told him the truth.

The pain was not simply that she had gone somewhere without him. It was the lie, and the way it made him question the meaning of the lunch they had shared the day before.

The argument brought out things Shiva did that Akshara did not like. She blocked him everywhere. The channels through which he had reached her went silent. There was no last message he could answer, no explanation he could ask for, no way to make his apology or anger land.

A THOUGHT TO KEEP

“Sometimes a person becomes family in your heart before you realise they never promised to stay.”

CHAPTER 3

When Efforts Became One Sided

December 2024 — A Message at Midnight

Months passed. Akshara created a new Instagram account. Shiva sent follow requests more than once. Each time, the request was rejected. He could tell himself to stop, but another part of him remembered how naturally they had once spoken.

In December 2024, he sent her a birthday message at midnight: “Happiest b day, Akshara.” The reply was brief: “Ahh, thank you.”

When Shiva’s birthday came, Akshara wished him too—but near the end of the day. He noticed the difference, even if he wished he did not. He had once been the person who remembered first. Now the message arrived when the day was almost over.

His school friends still teased them and spoke badly about Akshara, not understanding what had happened. Shiva answered harshly when they insulted her. Eventually, he began keeping his distance from those friends too. He could not explain why he still defended someone from whom he felt so far away.

May 21, 2026 — The Request Returns

In May 2026, Akshara sent Shiva a follow request. The other person in her life had revealed a side of himself that hurt her, and that relationship had ended. She explained what she had faced and apologised for the past.

Shiva listened. The old instinct returned before caution could catch it: if Akshara was hurting, he wanted to help her heal. He believed her again. Their conversations became warm. When she felt low, he was available.

Akshara joined college for postgraduate study. Her availability changed. Messages became fewer. Shiva planned a surprise meeting, and when they met, he was happy to see her. Then Kowsik became part of the picture. Kowsik had studied at the same school as both of them.

Akshara began spending more time with him. She reminded Shiva not to return to his old self and not to let the past repeat. Shiva wondered whether he had really changed or had only learned to hide how much he needed the friendship to stay the same.

A THOUGHT TO KEEP

“A friendship can survive distance, but it struggles when only one person keeps reaching across it.”

CHAPTER 4

When Trust Finally Broke

The Question She Asked

During their friendship, Akshara had asked Shiva a question more than once: “Do you love me? Why would you sacrifice so much?”

Shiva’s answer came from the same belief: “You’re my best friend. I just want you to be happy.”

He meant it. He did not keep a list of gifts or count each conversation as something Akshara owed him back. But over time, the sacrifices left a question behind: if he was willing to keep making room for her, why did he feel he had to beg for a little room in return?

He was afraid that asking for consistency would make him selfish. He was afraid that admitting he was hurt would sound like a demand. So he tried to be understanding, then tried harder, then blamed himself when understanding did not bring them closer.

October 2026 — The Truth About Kowsik

The news did not arrive like a scene in a film. There was no dramatic announcement, no perfect sentence that made everything clear. Shiva came to understand that Akshara and Kowsik had moved from friendship into a relationship.

For a moment, the information seemed to sit outside him, as if it belonged to someone else’s life. Then the old memories began attaching themselves to it: the Instagram request, the Diwali wish, the watch she liked, the keychain she gave him,

the lunch before his birthday, the birthday lie, the blocking, the apology, the May request, the surprise meeting.

He had trusted that Akshara would not do this to their friendship. He believed that even if her life changed, the bond they had built would remain protected from being quietly pushed aside. Now he was trying to understand whether he had mistaken the meaning of their closeness—or whether its meaning had changed along the way.

Akshara said, “I didn’t mean to hide it from you. I didn’t know how to tell you, and I didn’t want another fight.” Shiva read the words twice. He could believe that she had not planned to hurt him and still feel hurt by what had happened. Her explanation did not erase the shock; it only showed him that they had been carrying different expectations of the same friendship.

He cried. He was angry. He felt foolish for trusting again, then guilty for calling himself foolish. He could not switch off four years because the friendship had reached a point he had never imagined.

A THOUGHT TO KEEP

“The truth does not always arrive loudly. Sometimes one small detail makes every old memory hurt again.”

CHAPTER 5

No More Begging for a Place

Learning to Step Back

After learning about Akshara and Kowsik, Shiva did not suddenly become strong. He did not wake the next morning free of memories, nor did he find a clean sentence that explained what to do with four years of attachment.

He was angry with Akshara. He was angry with himself for believing again. Some days he wanted an explanation that would make the story fit together; other days he did not want to hear another explanation at all. The friendship had become a room in his mind where every object still stood where it used to, even though he no longer had a key.

He began separating himself from people. His school friends did not know the real shape of the hurt. Other people had their own lives. Shiva could not explain why this loss felt so large when, from the outside, they had only been best friends.

He had begged before—not always with the word itself, but through repeated messages, requests, apologies, and attempts to return to how things were. He had asked for the friendship not to end. He had tried to make himself easier to keep.

Now he was tired. But tiredness is not peace. Stopping the begging did not mean he had stopped caring. It meant he had reached a point where he no longer knew what another message could possibly repair.

A THOUGHT TO KEEP

“You can care deeply for someone and still need to stop asking them to make room for you.”

CHAPTER 6

What She Lost

Shiva did not know whether Akshara would one day look back and understand the depth of his loyalty. He could not know what she felt, what she regretted, or how she would remember the friendship. This was the part he could not control.

What he knew was what the friendship had meant to him. He had treated her like family. When she was low, he tried to help her stand. When people spoke badly about her, he defended her. When she returned after distance, he opened the door again. He believed that a connection built over years would leave room for an honest conversation.

One evening, he opened an old photo—the two of them standing across the road from school, young enough to believe a friendship could remain exactly as it felt that day. He looked at the picture for a while. He did not delete it. He did not send it to her. He simply locked his phone and sat in the quiet.

A THOUGHT TO KEEP

“Not begging anymore is not the same as no longer caring.”

A Final Note

Shiva has not fully moved on. He is still hurt, angry, and unsure what to do next. The ending leaves him where he truly is: carrying memories without knowing what to do with them.